

in Japan and China,” he says. The route followed by the big three is clearly different. Obviously, as a country gets richer and spending power increases, luxury goods stand to gain. All three conglomerates have invested heavily in Indian designer-led brands. Prominent examples are the ABG investing in Sabyasachi and Reliance in Manish Malhotra, Raghavendra Rathore, Ritu Kumar, or the Tatas in e-commerce through Tata Cliq. “One reason to tie up with luxury brands through joint ventures or licensing, while investing in Indian-born designer brands, could be to learn from the foreign brands and grow the Indian brands,” Som says.

Asthana points out that for Indian consumers, luxury goes beyond access to global brands. “It is about authenticity, cultural relevance, and the meaning attached to a purchase,” he says. The moment it is personalised and with immersive storytelling, there is a clear reason to engage and eventually buy. “Tailoring the message to the Indian market is crucial to establishing a deeper connection, and that could be through collaborations with local designers or narratives to link products to Indian traditions or occasions. For instance, Bvlgari introduced the *kada* and *mangalsutra* for Indian consumers,” adds Asthana.

It is an indication of how much India matters and why the strategy must be different. Anurag Mathur, Partner & Head of Bain & Company’s retail practice in India, says unlocking significant growth requires creating aspiration and relevance specifically to Indian consumers. Within this is an appreciation of assets like jewellery and luxury real estate, or the experience that comes with it. “Recognising this, global brands have started taking the Indian consumer more seriously and now tailor their offerings and marketing campaigns,” he says. For instance, Louis Vuitton has launched *Rani Pink* and Dior held a fall show in Mumbai. Indian celebrities, like Alia Bhatt and Deepika Padukone,

BREAK-UP OF THE INDIAN LUXURY MARKET		
Grouping	Annual gross household income (In ₹ lakh)	No of households (In millions)
Elite+	>50	1
Elite	20-50	9
Affluent	10—20	26
Aspirers	5—10	59
Next billion	1.5-5	130
Remaining	<1.5	64
TOTAL		289

SOURCE BCG REPORT

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“Luxury for Indians is about authenticity, cultural relevance, and the meaning attached to a purchase.”

GOPAL ASTHANA
CEO, TATA CLIQ



“Now, they (global brands) are making a direct entry or through a joint venture, meaning there is more skin in the game.”

PUSHPA BECTOR
SENIOR ED, DLF RETAIL